

Jain Temples, Mount Abu

Location Rajasthan, India

There are five Jain temples in the high, wooded hill station that is Mount Abu. Collectively known as the Dilwara Temples, they were built between the 11th and 13th centuries. The most famed are the two oldest: the Vimala Vasahi, built in c.1030, and the Luna Vasahi, built in 1230. They are dedicated, respectively, to the first and the 22nd of the *tirthankaras*, the 24 most esteemed figures in Jainism. Inside and out, these domed temples burst with intricately carved details, including dancing figures, geometric patterns, and tiny spires projecting down as well as up. However overwhelming this remarkable decorative program appears, the impact is never oppressive. Both buildings are made of white marble and gleam with light.

Rukn-e-Alam

Location Multan, Pakistan

The Rukn-e-Alam, “Pillar of the World,” is the tomb of an Islamic mystic. It was built between 1320 and 1324 by a local ruler, Tughluq I. This astonishing building, both sturdy and delicate, is octagonal in plan and built mostly of red brick. Eight inward-leaning, tapering buttresses support the massive base of the structure, and the whole is elaborately banded with incised patterns and turquoise tiles. At the summit of each buttress is a white dome. Above these is another even more opulently decorated octagon, studded with blue and turquoise glazed tiles and pierced by arches, each angle marked by further domes. Above all this, slightly set back, is a brilliantly white hemispherical dome that rises to a height of 115 ft (35 m).

Wuxianguan Temple

Location Guangzhou, China

The Taoist Wuxianguan Temple in Guangzhou, formerly Canton, in southern China, is also known as the Temple of the Five Immortals. It commemorates the arrival of five immortals from the heavens—three men and two women—said to have been riding goats and carrying food during a time of famine, possibly in the Zhou dynasty (c.1030–771 BCE). They brought with them “the gift of rice cultivation and the promise of bountiful harvests.” Today’s temple is a late 19th-century replica of a Ming dynasty building of 1378, the original having been destroyed by a fire. Its sharply upward-curling, yellow-and-green tiled eaves are alive with finials and statuary. A deep-red, sturdy, arched tower houses a Ming bell weighing 5.5 tons (5 tonnes).

Drum Tower of Xi'an

Location Xi'an, China

Xi'an’s imposing Drum Tower is one of two almost identical structures built early in the Ming dynasty (1368–1644). The Drum Tower dates from 1380, and its sister building, the Bell Tower, from 1384. Both stand on substantial brick bases and are built of elaborately decorated brick and wood, with three eaves of glazed, dark green tiles. Their purpose was partly to assert Ming imperial might and partly to act as timekeepers—the bell was rung to signal a new day, and the drum was struck to signal its end. Although the original drum is no longer there, a new drum—the largest in China—was placed there in 1996. Twelve vivid red drums line the exterior of the north and south sides of the building’s second floor.

Taimiao Ancestral Temple

Location Beijing, China

Although it lies just outside the Forbidden City (see pp.276–277), the complex of ordered buildings that make up the Taimiao Ancestral Temple, built from 1420, was sacred to both the Ming and Qing dynasties. As the name suggests, it was here that the ancestors of emperors and empresses were venerated. The complex consists of several separate structures, most of them dedicated to lesser nobles and courtiers. The most important and largest structure—reached by the complex’s principal entrance, the Halberd Gate—is the Hall for Worship of Ancestors. This long, low building is twin-eaved and rests on a three-tiered base. Under its overhanging eaves are elaborate glazed green, blue, and cream tiles. Following the Chinese Communist Revolution in 1949, the complex became the Beijing Working People’s Cultural Palace, where cultural events are held.



▲ DETAILED MARBLE CARVINGS IN THE JAIN TEMPLES AT MOUNT ABU